CHAPTER 5

THE LAST DANCE – DAY ONE

10 July 2024, 10:17am

ENGLAND vs WEST INDIES, 1st Test, *Lord's – Day 1*

West Indies 121 all out; England 189/3

'Enjoy every moment,' I'm telling Jamie Smith, born three years before my Test debut, 'because the end comes much quicker than you think.' Even this morning, it feels like time is slipping out of my hands, moving quicker than I can ever remember it moving. It all feels really rushed. No one mentions anything before the game. There are no speeches. No addresses for anyone to make. I don't want them to. I want to be inside a real Test match one more time, all focus on winning for England. I'm lacing up my boots in the same place I've sat in at Lord's for 15 years, gravity pulling me towards the centre of the room, when Ben Stokes takes a seat next to me. 'Do you know anything about what's happening this morning?' No, I tell him, apart from my girls ringing the bell on the balcony. 'Well, there's going to be a video and then you're going to lead us out on to the field.'

It's my worst nightmare – I don't tell him – to be lined up in the Long Room, next to the West Indies players, while a video plays out across the huge screens at Lord's. I am caught between the sadness of not being the centre of attention on the pitch imminently, that beautiful feeling of having the ball in my hand and knowing everything is within my control, and actually being the centre of attention now in a way that is deeply unsettling to me. I'm wrestling with it all; the present and the past, the warmth and the cold, the gratitude and the hurt, the spotlight and the shade, the life and the death. As we leave the dressing room to make our way down the famous